leaders are also facing legal action, which the Opposition conveniently overlooks." Under the Yogi government, legal action is taken "as per the law and without bias", he insists.

That said, there is no denying that the alleged "criminal-political overlap" has left many Muslim leaders vulnerable. Once stripped of political protection, their legal troubles escalated rapidly. The BJP's sustained dominance has deepened this marginalisation, with Muslim figures unable to mount a credible counter. Indeed, for parties like the SP or BSP, it is now difficult to even promote Muslim leaders without risking a backlash.

WHEELS WITHIN WHEELS

But there are other factors at play as well. Hilal Ahmed, political scientist and professor at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS), feels that the reasons for Muslim representation declining in UP are more due to changing political strategies than overt exclusion. He goes back to the emphasis on the winnability factor. "At present, the political discourse is dominated by Hindutva, no political party can ignore that. Because of this, the term 'Muslim' has acquired a negative connotation. Even leaders like (SP chief) Akhilesh Yadav have shifted from using the term 'Muslim' to 'minorities'," he points out.

Hilal also believes that political narratives heavily influence leaders as well as the electorate. "Earlier, from around 1992 to 2010, secularism was the dominant narrative in Indian politics. Every political party wanted to be called secular, even the BJP, which described others as 'pseudo-secularists' while still embracing the label for itself," he notes. "Today, the environment is very divisive. If that does not change, it will become difficult to imagine any form of non-identitarian politics."

But then, winning elections is just one part of democracy, asserting India's pluralistic values is another. "We do need Muslim MPs and MLAs to make our institutions inclusive and diverse. But we should not ask political parties to give tickets to Muslims, or expect that Muslims will vote only for Muslim candidates. Instead, we should expect parties to recognise Muslim presence in the legislative chambers," says the CSDS professor. Hilal also flagged the growing lack of internal inclusiveness within the political parties themselves, warning that if such trends continue, the very meaning of democracy risks being reduced to just contesting and winning elections.

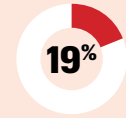
Even within the Opposition ranks, the signs of discomfort are visible. The SP's decision to name Azam Khan a star campaigner in the 2024 Lok Sabha election despite his imprisonment drew internal criticism and highlighted a growing unease over the party's traditional formula of minority consolidation. The absence of a strong, unifying leadership has also left the vote fragmented, which is again cited as a reason for multiple Muslim candidates sprouting in community stronghold seats. Newer outfits like Asaduddin Owaisi's AIMIM (All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen) and Chandra Shekhar Azad's Azad Samaj Party have tried to fill the vacuum, but have yet to gain meaningful ground.

The results of the assembly bypolls in November 2024, where the SP lost in Muslim strongholds such as Kundarki, Meerapur and Rampur, show that revival is a long way off. Kundarki, in particular, exemplified this crisis. The constituency has over 60 per cent Muslims, the local MP is from the community (Zia Ur Rehman Barq from Sambhal), and the BJP had not won here in over 30 years. But this time the BJP did, with party candidate Ramveer Singh taking an unprecedented 76 per cent of the vote. The Opposition had its share of excuses—the 10 dummy Muslim candidates (other than the SP nominee), security officials allegedly not allowing Muslim voters to come out and vote in certain areas—but couldn't evade the elephant in the room, the fact that a sizeable section of the community had voted for the saffron party. This also segues into Prof. Hilal's argument that "it's a false assumption that Muslims will automatically vote for Muslim candidates."

One must laud the community's efforts at staying ahead of the polarisation debate in UP, but the collapse of the old Muslim leadership model elicits broader questions, not just about minority representation but about the kind of leadership that is required to take its place. ■

NOWHERE TO GO

Muslim representation has been on a downslide in UP's legislatures

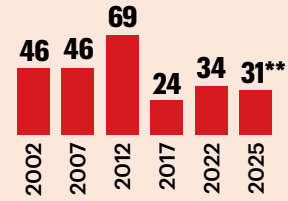


Share of Muslims in UP's population

5 Muslims out of 100 MLCs*

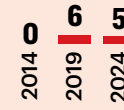
MLAs in assembly

Total seats: 403



Lok Sabha MPs

Total seats: 80



**Member of Legislative Council; ** (after disqualification and bypoll losses)*

While the old model of Muslim leadership has collapsed, no new strong unifying leadership has taken its place, leaving the vote fragmented